

MAN'S NEW BEST FRIEND



Teen befriends injured owl, finds it medical help

By Leslie Weaver
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GASTONIA — Scottie Rowland and his Mom went looking for some peaches but came home with an injured owl.

His mother, Pam Rowland, said their trip to Filbert, S.C., to pick peaches turned out to be "almost unbelievable."

"We had been there for 30 minutes when I heard my son yell, 'there is an owl in front of me and it's a real one,'" she said. "When Scottie finally got within five feet of the owl it tried to walk but kept falling on its face."

Scottie, 14, is an animal lover at heart. His mother says whenever he sees one that is hurt he wants to bring it home.

That's exactly what he did this time.

"He wrapped his T-shirt around it and brought it home. We knew it was hurt," she said. "He sat on the porch holding it. The owl put his head on his arm and went to sleep."

Word about Scottie's discovery spread quickly through the neighborhood and children clamored to the Rowland house to get a look at the owl.

"He let the neighborhood children pet him on the head," said Mrs. Rowland.

No one was more shocked to see Scottie holding a 5-month-old Barred Owl than the officials from Carolina Raptor Center sent to pick up the owl.

"They sent a guy named Rick out to get the bird. He told me that no one should touch it," Mrs. Rowland said. "I told him it was too late."

Scottie's new friend has been taken to the raptor center in Huntersville where injured birds of prey are nursed back to health and then released into the wild again.

Scottie plans to call and check on the owl's progress as it is nursed back to health.

The Carolina Raptor Center is open to the public from 10 a.m.-5 p.m. Tuesday-Sunday.

It's located in Latta Plantation Park, 6000 Sample Road, Charlotte.

The center includes a museum with exhibits of more than 20 species of birds of prey in aviaries.

For more information about the center call 875-6521.

Scottie Rowland, 14, went to pick peaches at an orchard and found a wild owl.

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